Jordan, Kobe and LeBron: Career Performance and Finals Audiences

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Abstract

This project compares Michael Jordan, Kobe Bryant and LeBron James using full regular-season career statistics and U.S. television audiences for Finals series featuring each player. The data contain three career summaries and 23 Finals appearances. Jordan has the highest scoring average, while LeBron has the highest rebound and assist averages. Jordan's Finals appearances have the highest mean audience in these records. LeBron's mean audience exceeds Kobe's when 2020 is excluded, demonstrating sensitivity to scope. Jersey-sales rankings are supplementary.

Introduction

How do these players compare in career production and the audiences for their Finals appearances? We combine these ideas to see who performed best but as well as who left a legacy that garnered fans to tune in on the game of basketball. We examine them as separate measurable dimensions instead of assuming that one statistic defines greatness. The current analysis describes the complete selected career snapshots and Finals records. It does not draw a random sample of all possible basketball players or broadcasts.

Executive summary

- Jordan leads career PPG; LeBron leads career RPG and APG among these players.
- Jordan's series-average Finals audience is the largest in the collected data.
- Removing 2020 changes the ordering of LeBron's and Kobe's audience means.
- Published jersey ranks lack the coverage and sales quantities needed for a career-wide three-player sales comparison.

Data and methods

StatMuse supplies three full regular-season career summaries: games, points, PPG, RPG, APG and shooting percentages. These are the retrieved snapshot, not a live feed as Lebron is currently active on this list. Jordan's six seasonal performance rows were replaced in the comparison by his career summary.

Sports Media Watch and Front Office Sports provide 23 Finals-series audience records: Jordan (6), Kobe (7) and LeBron (10). Variables include player, year, opponent, series games, championship result, audience, method and a pandemic flag. Audience is average U.S. viewers per game in millions, not worldwide or unique career viewers. Kobe and Jordan use reported series averages; LeBron uses means of rounded game figures from the historical archive. This source precision difference and historical measurement changes remain limitations.

The cleaning RMD trims names, converts numeric fields, checks duplicate keys and missing required values, derives audience units and a 2020 flag, and saves processed CSVs and an RData environment. It recomputes descriptive summaries. The standardized input tables already reflect earlier collection and unit conversion; this workflow does not recreate the original web extraction. No valid Finals series was dropped. Unknown jersey quantities remain missing.

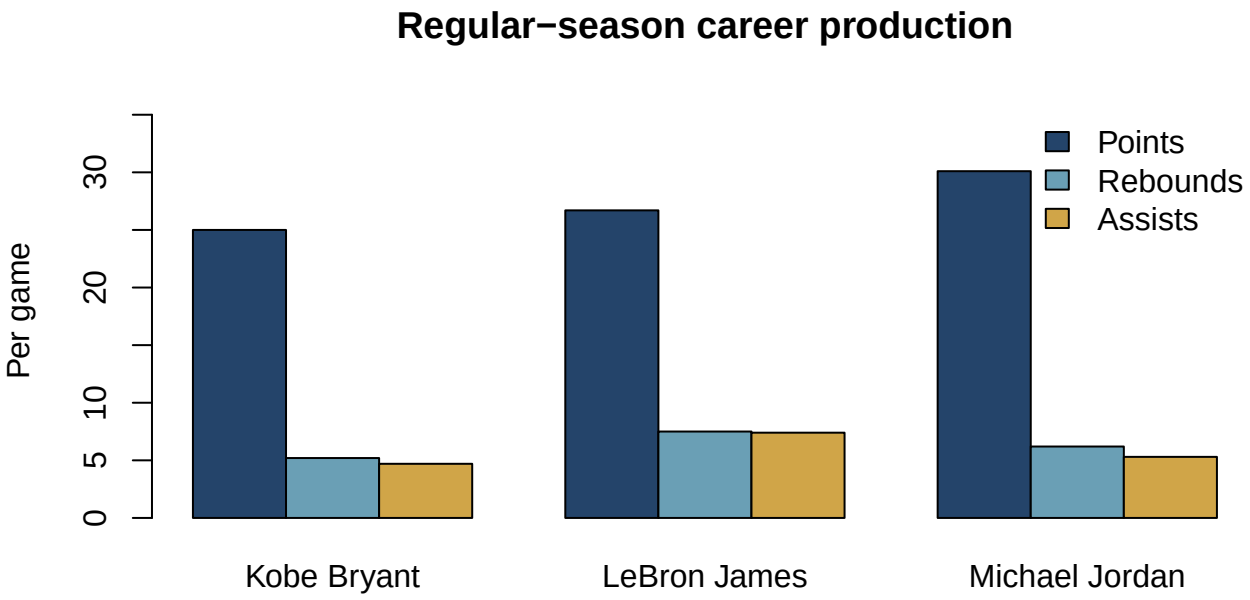
Six jersey-ranking entries and two Cleveland-return game audiences are retained as supplementary records. The latter are excluded from Finals summaries. Means and medians give each Finals series equal weight. A game-weighted mean is also saved by the processing file; it is approximate for rounded source data.

Results

Preliminary visualizations and findings

Career production

Player	Games	TotalPoints	PPG	RPG	APG
Kobe Bryant	1346	33643	25.0	5.2	4.7
LeBron James	1627	43522	26.7	7.5	7.4
Michael Jordan	1072	32292	30.1	6.2	5.3

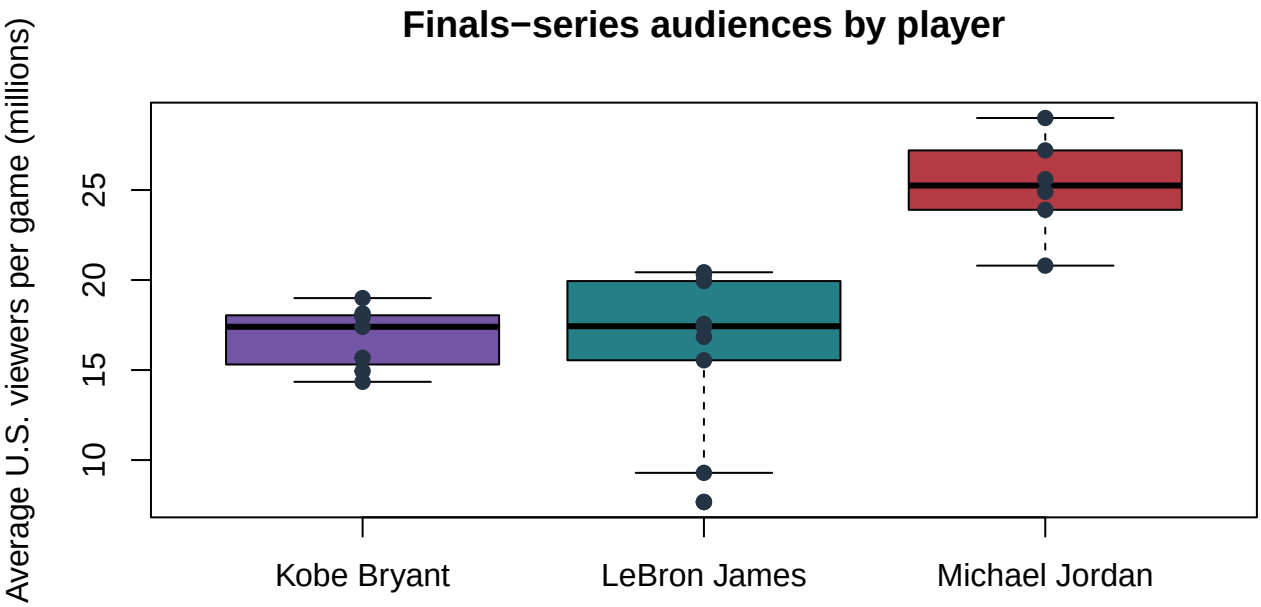


Jordan has the highest career scoring average (30.1 PPG), while LeBron has the highest rebound (7.5 RPG) and assist (7.4 APG) averages in this snapshot. Kobe averaged 25.0 PPG, 5.2 RPG and 4.7 APG. These statistics describe different contributions and do not measure defense, shot difficulty or era-adjusted value.

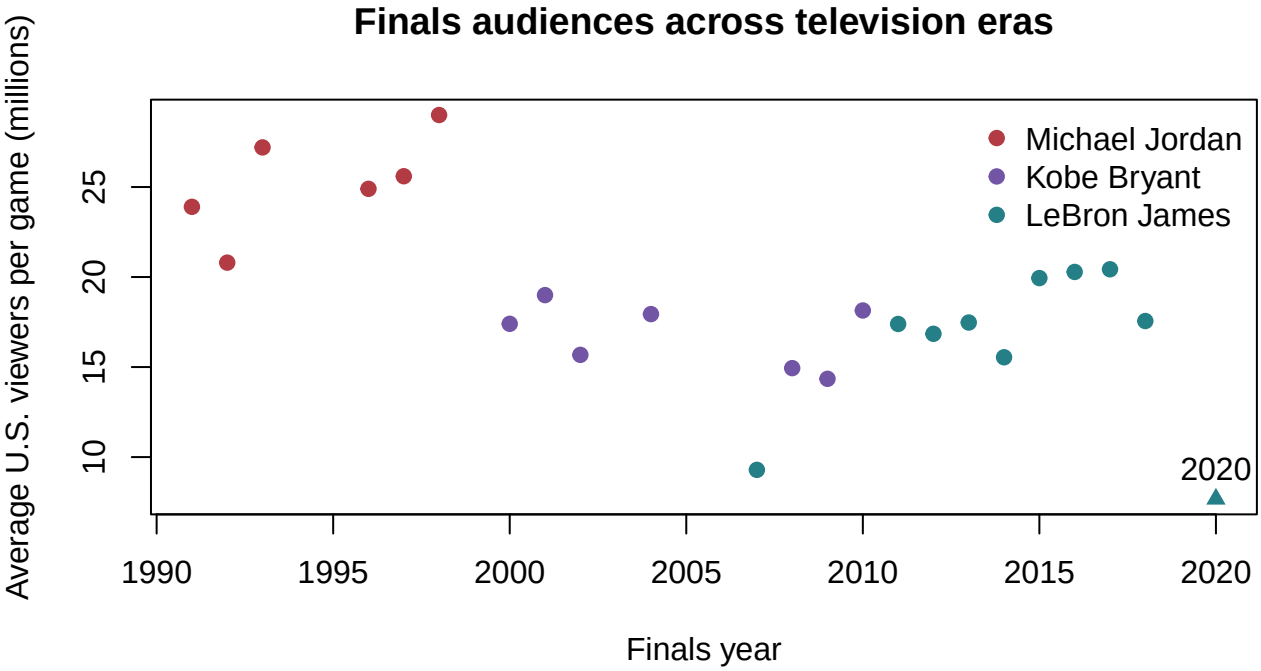
Finals audiences

Table 1: Series audience summaries in millions; equal weight per series

Player	Series	Mean	Median	SD	Minimum	Maximum
Kobe Bryant	7	16.779	17.402	1.781	14.347	18.996
LeBron James	10	16.244	17.434	4.407	7.672	20.432
Michael Jordan	6	25.233	25.250	2.819	20.800	29.000



Mean series audiences are approximately 25.23 million for Jordan, 16.78 million for Kobe, and 16.24 million for LeBron. These are conditional on Finals appearances and reflect team matchups and television eras. They do not establish how many viewers each player caused to watch.



Player and era are closely connected in these records. The scatterplot helps show this limitation; audience differences cannot be assigned to player identity alone. Keep the valid 2020 bubble observation and examine its influence.

Sensitivity to 2020

Table 2: Series audience summaries excluding 2020

Player	Series	Mean	Median	SD	Minimum	Maximum
Kobe Bryant	7	16.779	17.402	1.781	14.347	18.996
LeBron James	9	17.196	17.474	3.412	9.290	20.432

Player	Series	Mean	Median	SD	Minimum	Maximum
Michael Jordan	6	25.233	25.250	2.819	20.800	29.000

Excluding 2020 raises LeBron's equal-series mean to about 17.20 million, compared with 16.24 million when all his appearances are included. His mean then exceeds Kobe's 16.78 million in this dataset. Jordan's and Kobe's results are unchanged. This shows why the scope must be stated alongside any ranking.

Jersey popularity: selected reporting periods

Table 3: Selected published jersey rankings; lower rank means higher placement

Player	ReportDateOrYear	SalesRank
Michael Jordan	2003	4
Kobe Bryant	2003	1
Kobe Bryant	2011-04-14	2
LeBron James	2011-04-14	1
Kobe Bryant	2012-04-26	3
LeBron James	2012-04-26	4

In the cited 2003 list, Kobe ranked first and Jordan fourth. In the NBA's April 2011 release, LeBron ranked first and Kobe second; in April 2012, Kobe ranked third and LeBron fourth. These are selected historical snapshots with differing periods and retail scopes. They are not career sales totals. Units sold and revenue are unavailable, so the current data cannot support a three-player career jersey-sales ranking. Additional matched-period data would be needed.

Further visualization and analysis plan

We plan on adding comparable Finals-specific player performance records if exploring performance versus audience; repeating career averages over Finals rows would not supply independent performance observations. As well as explore opponent, series length and television era before considering regression. This can give context and maybe a sense of difficulty each player had to face, which would add better support for the question of the better player.

Limitations

Career lengths, playing roles, pace, teammates and rules differ. Finals-only selection excludes seasons without an appearance. Television access and measurement methods changed over time, and the pandemic shifted the 2020 schedule. Rounding and audience averaging methods differ across sources. These conditions prevent causal attribution of audiences to a player and a single definitive GOAT conclusion.

Reproducibility

For reproducibility please refer to the README within the project package folder, further directions in the first README.

Github here

Sources

ID	Source	Data
S1	StatMuse career comparison	Jordan, Kobe, and LeBron regular-season career statistics
S2	Sports Media Watch: 2010 Finals and historical averages	Kobe's seven Finals-series audiences
S3	Front Office Sports: Most-watched NBA Finals	Jordan's six Finals-series audiences; credits Sports Media Watch
S4	Sports Media Watch: Finals ratings history	Game audiences used to calculate LeBron's ten series averages
S5	Sports Media Watch: Cleveland return games	Two supplementary LeBron regular-season games
S6	NBA Communications: jersey rankings	Kobe's 2010–11 NBAStore.com jersey rank
S7	ESPN: 2010 NBA Finals	Supporting check for Kobe's 2010 Finals audience
S8	USA Basketball: Kobe Bryant	Background reference only

Career statistics are the StatMuse snapshot returned November 6, 2026. LeBron's totals can change. Kobe source files recorded November 1, 2026; the supplied LeBron report recorded November 2, 2026.

All viewership is U.S. audience per game in millions. Kobe/Jordan use reported series averages; LeBron uses arithmetic means of rounded game figures. The workbook labels the method. These are comparable measures with source precision and historical measurement differences, not perfectly identical measurement systems. Keep 2020 flagged.

Jordan's seasonal performance rows are excluded from the career-only comparison. Cleveland-return games and jersey rank remain supplementary. No shoe-revenue or ticket-sales data was supplied.

Summary of Individual Contribution

Rhein Lipardo: Kobe Portion Research, Standardized data, Standardized visualizations, Final Report, Github

Axcan Martinez: Jordan Research

Ismail Ashour: Lebron Research